

## RESEARCH NOTE

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# Exploring the dimensions of NGO donor-based brand equity: A literature review

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**Abstract**

The increasing participation of nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) in addressing developmental issues has resulted in a surge of NGOs globally and, consequently, intensified the competition among them for donations. NGOs, a type of nonprofit organization (NPO), have a distinctive characteristic: promoting a particular cause, which often pertains to social and political issues in an international context. The enhanced brand equity of NGOs can result in increased donor attraction, leading to a rise in both their amount of donations and donor loyalty. Conceptualizations of NGO brand equity, however, are scarce. This study thus critically reviews the current literature on NPO brand equity and proposes some guidelines for future, distinctive donor-based brand equity models for NGOs. Our results also have important managerial implications for NGOs, highlighting relevant aspects in the brand equity building process that suggest future lines of research.

**KEYWORDS**

brand equity, charities, donors, NGO, nonprofit, NPO

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## 1 | INTRODUCTION

Positioned between the market and government, nonprofit organizations (NPOs) play a crucial role in mobilizing private motivation for the common good (Salamon, 2003). With more than 10 million NPOs worldwide, including nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), foundations, and charities, these organizations perform a wide variety of social, economic, and political services. Their areas of activity are broad, including the defense of civil rights, education, health, economic development, arts and culture, sports and recreation, international aid, and civic and social activities (Boris & Steuerle, 2006).

While all NPOs are inherently nonprofit, they present different legal constitutions and confront disparate challenges in their brand management due to their distinct legal constitutions and fields of action.

Table 1 reveals significant differences among various categories of NPOs; however, researchers frequently use the term NPO to refer to foundations, charities, and NGOs without distinguishing between them. As a result, there is a scarcity of literature specifically devoted to building NGO brand equity.

NGOs are value-based organizations (Stride, 2006) defined, according to Salamon and Anheier (1992) and Vakil (1997), as prosocial, self-governing, private, not-for-profit organizations that have a distinctive characteristic: promoting a particular cause, which often pertains to social and political issues, such as humanitarian aid, welfare, freedom, justice, and equal rights, with the aim of improving the lives of vulnerable people. Another aspect that differentiates NGOs from NPOs is that while NGOs are often involved in international advocacy for social and political change, NPOs focus more on providing direct services to meet specific needs in their local community (Salamon & Anheier, 1992; Unerman & O'Dwyer, 2006; Vakil, 1997).

NGOs' moral objectives necessitate particular management principles (Jones et al., 2007) that distinguish them from other NPOs in the eyes of donors, as they require higher moral capital and social legitimacy than other NPOs to fulfill their moral aims (Kane, 2001). Furthermore, for donors to provide donations, they need to identify with an NGO's brand values. The degree of alignment between a donor's moral values and an NGO's moral objectives affects the level of support the former is willing to provide to the organization (Goenka & van Osselaer, 2019; Gregory et al., 2020; Sargeant et al., 2008; Wymer et al., 2021). For instance, donors who support Greenpeace or World Vision do so because they share their values and goals, protecting the environment or children; however, such moral identification is not as necessary when donating to other NPOs, such as the National Academy of Fine Arts (Boenigk & Becker, 2016; Gregory et al., 2020; Venable, 2005; Voeth & Herbst, 2008). Given these differences, we contend that NGOs' management differs from that of other types of NPOs, especially regarding how they build donor-based brand equity.

The most widely adopted definition of brand equity is that of Aaker (1991): a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol, which adds to or subtracts from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or its customers. Similarly, NGO donor-based brand equity refers to the differential effect that NGO brand has on donor NGO preference and intention to donate. Aaker (1991) considers four dimensions of brand equity, *brand awareness*, *brand association*, *loyalty*, and *perceived quality*, and studies the influence of each on brand equity.

Positive brand equity cause a product to be chosen over its competition by recognizing and differentiating the brand, causing positive associations that facilitate loyalty to it (Aaker, 1991; Yoo & Donthu, 2001).

TABLE 1 Foundations, charities and NGOs characteristics.

| Basis for comparison                                                                                                                  | Foundation                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Charity                                                                                                                                         | NGO                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| None of corporation's net profit from donations, membership fees, or business activities will benefit any individual (Hansmann, 1980) | ✓                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | ✓                                                                                                                                               | ✓                                                                                                                                                       |
| Law requirements                                                                                                                      | Can be registered as a Trust under Public Trust Act, or as a Society as a Societies Registration Act, 1860 or as a non-profit company under the Companies Act, 1956 + local countries specifications. (Salamon & Anheier, 1992) | Charities Act of 2011 (UK Office of the Third Sector 2006) ACNC Standard (Australia) (Salamon & Sokolowski, 2016)                               | Article 71 UN Charter + local countries specifications (Martens, 2002)                                                                                  |
| Objectives                                                                                                                            | To promote art, science, research, health, sports, business, and professional associations (Salamon & Anheier, 1996)                                                                                                            | Churches, educational organizations, hospitals and medical research, state colleges, or universities (Forrester, 2023; Unerman & O'Dwyer, 2006) | To work for the betterment of society. Humanitarian aid and welfare causes or freedom, justice, and equal rights (Salamon & Anheier, 1992; Vakil, 1997) |
| Usual area of operation                                                                                                               | Local                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Local                                                                                                                                           | International (Werker & Ahmed, 2008)                                                                                                                    |
| Core donors base                                                                                                                      | Trusts, endowment (Salamon & Anheier, 1992)                                                                                                                                                                                     | Individuals, organizations (Salamon & Anheier, 1992)                                                                                            | Individuals; public fundings to a limited extend (Martens, 2002)                                                                                        |
| Management                                                                                                                            | Mainly paid employees (Salamon & Anheier, 1992)                                                                                                                                                                                 | Mixture of paid employees and volunteers (Salamon & Sokolowski, 2016)                                                                           | Mixture of paid employees and volunteers (Gordenker & Weiss, 1995; Martens, 2002)                                                                       |

Cultivating strong NGO donor-based brand equity is important for NGO fundraising, which is critical for NGO survival (Ha et al., 2022). In a growing and competitive “NGO market” where attracting and maintaining donors is an ongoing concern (Michel & Rieunier, 2012), building strong donor-based brand equity is highly relevant. An NGO with strong brand equity

is likely to attract donors who are more engaged and committed to the focal organization, leading to increased donations and greater loyalty.

To explore the factors that influence the formation of NGO brand equity, we conduct a comprehensive review of the literature on branding in NPOs and NGOs. We examine 511 papers from the Scopus and Web of Science (WOS) databases published between 2000 and 2022 (see Appendix 1 for more details). We then classify the literature by each brand equity dimension from Aaker's (1991) most widely used model, identify the existing research gaps concerning NGO particularities and propose new avenues for future conceptualizations of a novel NGO brand equity model from the donor perspective.

Our study therefore makes two important contributions to the NGO literature. First, it contributes to the NGO management literature by deepening the understanding of NGO brand equity building. Second, it assists managers involved in NGO marketing by reassessing the dimensions of brand equity and suggesting adaptations and mechanisms that will allow them to strengthen their NGO's donor-based brand equity and develop appropriate marketing strategies that further enhance it.

## 2 | LITERATURE REVIEW

Although the concept of brand equity has been extensively investigated in the business literature, we found very few studies that explicitly address NPO brand equity models and none that explicitly refer to NGO brand equity. The main focus in the NPO brand literature is thus a donor's intention to donate and how some NPO brand attributes affect and/or influence this intention positively. NPO brand equity models in the literature are also adaptations of brand concepts concerning for-profit organizations, mainly Aaker's (1991) model. However, these NPO models are difficult to generalize, as they typically rely on tailored measurement scales specific to the unique characteristics of the focal NPO (Bennett & Gabriel, 2003; Ewing & Napoli, 2005; Faircloth, 2005; Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Venable, 2005; Voeth & Herbst, 2008). Therefore, there is not yet a generally accepted brand equity model suitable for NGOs.

## 3 | RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

To fulfill our objective to generalize an NGO donor-based brand equity model, we group and discuss the following literature review based on Aaker's (1991) consumer-based brand equity dimensions, which are the most widely used (Ishaq & Di Maria, 2020; Romero et al., 2023). The dimensions included in Aaker's model are *brand awareness*, *brand association*, *loyalty*, and *perceived quality*. First, we review how these dimensions have been analyzed in terms of their impact on donor behavior in the context of branding. Subsequently, we discuss the limited number of comprehensive models developed in the NPO and NGO literature on brand equity.

### 3.1 | Brand awareness

Aaker (1991) considers brand awareness a component of brand equity that ensures a brand is available for consumer consideration, either through recall or recognition. In the for-profit literature, the theories of mere exposure and signaling suggest that brand awareness alone

influences consumer decision-making, either by triggering an impulse purchase or by serving as a cue for perceived quality (Erdem & Swait, 1998).

However, the conceptualizations of NPO brand awareness that focus only on brand recall or recognition are insufficient in the NPO context; signaling is not enough, as donors require more than mere brand recognition. Therefore, most authors incorporate the dimension of brand familiarity, that is, the magnitude of knowledge about a brand (Keller, 2003) that determines its prominence in a donor's memory (Gregory et al., 2020). However, there is some controversy in the empirical results obtained thus far (Table A1 in Appendix 2).

NPOs are characterized by their moral engagements with social causes; hence, for NGOs, in contrast to other NPOs, positive brand familiarity should be related to their cause and its moral objectives. To impact NGO brand equity in a positive way, donors must not only recognize an NGO brand but also be familiar with its purpose and approve of it.

This captivation is strengthened when a donor is directly affected by an NGO's cause (e.g., cancer patients/relatives and cancer-focused NGOs); this can also facilitate the donor's trust in the NGO (Czepiel, 1990; Sargeant & Lee, 2002).

### 3.2 | Brand associations

Brand associations refer to the brand perceptions of individuals in their memory and are categorized as product, organizational, symbol, or personality associations (Aaker, 1991). Within brand associations, brand personality refers to “a set of human characteristics associated with the brand” (Aaker, 1997, p. 347), allowing the consumer to identify with the brand (Aaker, 1997; Keller, 1993). Brand image thus includes functional and symbolic brand associations (Aaker, 1991; Hankinson, 2001; Keller, 1993; Michel & Rieunier, 2012). Michaelidou et al. (2015) argue that brand personality and brand image therefore play different roles in the NPO context. Brand personality targets consumers (donors) and their self-concept when choosing an NPO; brand image refers both to the NPO itself and the image it projects to society.

NPO brand personality and brand image have been extensively reviewed in the NPO literature by different clusters of authors. Several studies have developed customized scales for these dimensions based on their focal NPO (Bennett & Gabriel, 2003; Faircloth, 2005; Michaelidou et al., 2015; Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Sargeant et al., 2008; Venable, 2005; Voeth & Herbst, 2008). Their objective has been to determine the predictive value of these associations for donors' intentions to contribute to an organization.

However, the customization of the associations to specific personality types makes it difficult to generalize these models to NGOs. For example, sophistication is a favorable trait in a cultural NPO, but, for a childcare NGO, sophistication is far less important than integrity or childhood values.

Some authors have researched broader associations, such as *integrity*, *reputation*, *commitment to the public good*, and *financial stability*. These associations highlight how critical donor trust is in the nonprofit context. According to Sargeant and Lee (2002), trust is the foundation of charity and voluntary organizations, one of the most important reasons that individuals donate (Hager & Hedberg, 2016). NPO trustworthiness therefore not only attracts donors but also prevents the negative influence of scandals and damaging press in the nonprofit sector (Faircloth, 2005; Hager & Hedberg, 2016; Hou et al., 2009; Sargeant et al., 2008; Venable, 2005) (Table A2 in Appendix 2).

Among NGOs, a more nuanced approach is needed that recognizes the distinction between the functional attributes of a brand (its cause) and the symbolic values thereof (its beliefs).

Donors need to link both the cause and the moral values of an organization. Therefore, among NGOs, brand associations should refer to their moral values and objectives rather than specific personality traits. NGO moral compliance facilitates donor connection and the image that a donor projects by partnering with an NGO. As NGOs are value-based organizations (Stride, 2006), donors choose one or more NGOs with a brand image that portrays the values they identify the most strongly with. Therefore, an NGO's donors will develop stronger self-identifications with than with other NGOs less related to their personal values.

### 3.3 | Loyalty

Loyalty has multiple definitions (Jacoby & Kyner, 1973) but is generally defined in terms of two aspects: Behavioral loyalty and attitudinal loyalty. Behavioral loyalty refers to the buying pattern of an individual, measured by repeat purchase, whereas attitudinal loyalty increases behavioral loyalty and affective commitment, influenced by the emotional aspects of an individual.

Although brand loyalty is crucial for building consumer-based brand equity (Oliver, 1997; Yoo & Donthu, 2001), there is limited research on brand loyalty in the NPO context. One possible explanation for this is that donors often contribute to multiple NPOs at the same time. Moreover, in humanitarian crises, donors may make donations without feeling committed to an organization's long-term goals or causes (Gregory et al., 2020). Another reason is that the act of donating is not in principle something that is necessary recurrent; therefore, it does not require continued action that expresses loyalty. Nevertheless, brand switching and donor attrition are key issues that NPO managers must address.

In the NPO literature, the term "commitment" is often used instead of "loyalty" (Boenigk & Becker, 2016) to describe a donor's attitudes and behaviors toward an organization that stem from a strong belief in and acceptance of the organization's goals.

Sargeant and Lee (2004) argue that emotional attachment to an NPO brand creates a sense of commitment that may lead to brand loyalty. Conversely, Bennett (2009) notes that donors who have low involvement with an NPO are more likely to switch to other organizations.

We therefore suggest that for an NGO, before demonstrating a commitment, a donor must have a favorable attitude toward its focal cause; only later will this donor choose a certain NGO. Indeed, people are inclined to support NGOs that align with their personal values and beliefs (Wymer & Akbar, 2019). If the moral objectives of an NGO are congruent with donors' values, they are more likely to consider donating to that organization. However, if donors do not feel connected to an organization's mission or values, they are unlikely to donate except in emergency situations (Gregory et al., 2020; Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007; Wymer et al., 2021). Therefore, donors may remain loyal to a cause that resonates with them and, as a result, remain loyal to multiple NGOs that advocate similar cause(s), such as Save the Children and World Vision (Sargeant, 2001; Table A3 in Appendix 2).

### 3.4 | Perceived quality

According to Aaker (1991), perceived quality is a key dimension of brand equity, defined as the overall assessment of the superiority or excellence of certain products or services based on a user's perceptions (Myers & Allan, 1981; Zeithaml, 1988).

Perceived quality is rarely discussed in the NPO brand equity literature, although donors' positive perceived quality is related to their retention and engagement (Sargeant, 2001). The nature of the *products* offered by NGOs makes their quality difficult for donors to verify, as they are not beneficiaries of these NGOs' actions, which usually occur abroad. Thus, donors must make decisions based on certain cues as they have limited means by which to verify the quality of NGOs' services (Prakash & Gugerty, 2010), affirming the importance of trust in these organizations.

Some of the heuristics indicators of NPO quality in the personality and brand image research discussed above include the traits integrity, reliability, commitment to the public good, reputation, and financial stability (Bennett & Gabriel, 2000; Katz, 2018; Michaelidou et al., 2015; Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Sargeant et al., 2008; Venable, 2005; Voeth & Herbst, 2008), which indicate how an NPO is carrying out its work and whether a donor can trust it. Using the SERVQUAL framework (Parasuraman et al., 1988), Sargeant (2001), and Jones and Shandiz (2015) thus show that the best dimensions for assessing service quality are reliability (a donor trusts an organization will do its job and that its funds will be used properly) and tangibles (physical facilities, staff, and communication).

On the other hand, an NPO's efficient use of donations and effectiveness in achieving its objectives (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007) create the perception of its performance. Thus, an NPO's performance can also indicate donors' confidence in the completion of its promoted work (Gregory et al., 2020; Sargeant et al., 2004).

For NGOs, demonstrating their quality, associated with their ethical performance, is therefore more necessary, as donors demand higher standards of moral capital from them. An NGO's legitimacy, unlike that of other NPOs, is based both on its clear accountability for its actions and its moral accountability regarding the beneficiaries of its cause (Slim, 2002). Given the difficulty of assessing the quality of the *products* provided by NGOs, we suggest that accountability and reporting tools effectively demonstrate organizational reliability and integrity when assessing perceived NGO quality. In this manner, donors can evaluate NGO performance and compare the qualities of different NGOs (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007; Wymer et al., 2021) (Table A4 in Appendix 2).

### 3.5 | Nonprofit brand equity models

In addition to each of the dimensions of Aaker's brand equity model, we have examined the NPO brand equity models in the literature. We found no single model that is broadly accepted in the NPO context; rather, different brand equity models are adapted to the specific characteristics of the focal organization, hindering their generalization.

Faircloth (2005) has proposed a nonprofit brand equity model from the perspective of volunteers and donors that includes brand awareness (recall, recognition, and familiarity). Under the association dimension, he differentiates between brand personality and brand image. Interestingly, Faircloth discovered a negative correlation between brand awareness and brand equity, contrary to his expectations. This finding indicates that if familiarity implies a negative perception of an NPO, the rejection of the organization is more evident. Similar outcomes have been reported by other authors; still others have found the opposite, depending on their research context (Dogan et al., 2021; Hou et al., 2009; Kashif et al., 2018; Paço et al., 2014).

From a theoretical perspective, Laidler-Kylander and Simonin (2009) propose an NPO brand equity model consisting of four dimensions: consistency, focus, trust, and partnership. These

authors also introduce the notion of internal branding by including in all their variables an internal dimension they consider critical in building brand equity in NPOs. However, this model has not yet been empirically tested.

From the donor identification perspective, Hou et al. (2009) have studied the effects of brand equity on the intention to donate by considering the mediating effect of the self-concept of individual donors. Their results indicate that brand personality and brand awareness strengthen the self-concept of individual donors, which in turn influences their intention to donate in a direct and meaningful way.

Juntunen et al. (2013) have developed a nonprofit brand equity model that incorporates both internal and external stakeholders. Used to measure the impact of brand image and brand awareness on the brand equity of the Military Driving School of the Finnish Defense Forces (FDF), this model provides evidence of their positive influence. Kashif et al. (2018) alone have explored the moderating impact of brand credibility on the donor-based brand equity model via a rather comprehensive approach, but only in the context of Islam in Pakistan.

Finally, Boenigk and Becker (2016) have proposed a novel measure of brand equity in NPOs, a nonprofit brand equity index from the perspective of volunteers and donors, the primary resource providers. Their index consists of three dimensions, brand awareness, brand trust, and brand commitment, which they employ to establish a brand equity index for 40 German NPOs. Nevertheless, these authors do not analyze the overall effect of brand equity on donor intention.

In summary, the current research on brand equity in the context of NPOs and NGOs is limited and inconclusive, with conflicting findings and a lack of generalizability. Additionally, the research models used in this area do not incorporate relevant dimensions of brand equity, such as loyalty and perceived quality, which impact brand equity according to the consumer literature and are also important in the NPO and NGO context.

## 4 | CONCLUSIONS

Through a critical review of the literature on NPO and NGO brand equity, this research explores the sources of donor-based brand equity for NGOs.

We find a generalization of the term “NPO” in the literature that encompasses all types of NPOs without considering important differences among them. This heterogeneity of the NPO sector might be a possible explanation for some of the inconclusive findings in this literature.

We contend that there are significant differences between NPOs and NGOs regarding brand equity. First, donors must identify with the cause and the social objectives of an NGO to trigger their intention to donate and their future commitment to this organization. Second, donors demand greater moral capital from NGOs than other types of NPOs, as the former address more sensitive causes. Thus, donors establish preferences for NGOs that reflect their personal values and allow them to project a positive image of themselves by associating with them. These peculiarities impact how NGOs build and legitimize their brands compared to other types of NPOs.

Hence, we highlight the limited and inconsistent NPO brand equity models and note that no single NPO brand equity model has been widely adopted, likely due to their customization to the unique characteristics of each focal organization.

Most brand equity models in the NPO literature have also adapted consumer-based brand equity models and thus primarily focus on brand awareness, brand personality, and

brand image. Hence, critical dimensions such as perceived quality and loyalty remain scarcely addressed in the NPO and NGO contexts. For NGOs, these models fail to consider the impact of donor identification with NGO cause and moral objectives on the development of brand equity. These gaps in the literature have significant implications for developing effective strategies to build brand equity. We suggest that future NGO donor-based brand equity models should move beyond merely assessing awareness and include the more nuanced and complex concept of positive knowledge, as well as new dimensions, such as attitudinal and behavioral commitment, to better reflect the meaning of loyalty.

Furthermore, it is essential to explore the factors that contribute to the perceived quality of an NGO. This topic raises various marketing, organizational, and managerial issues, which need to be considered when developing a comprehensive model of NGO brand equity. By doing so, we can better understand the various elements that contribute to the formation and strengthening of brand equity and develop strategies that enable NGOs to build a strong and positive brand image.

#### 4.1 | Managerial implications

The findings of our study have several practical and managerial implications. First, our results suggest that simply increasing brand awareness is not sufficient to establish strong donor-based brand equity. Instead, it is important for NGOs to disseminate their values and activities to ensure that donors become familiar with their objectives and to focus on building their reputation based on these values. Therefore, NGOs should consider targeted communication strategies that effectively communicate their values to potential donors to build their brand equity.

Second, our study highlights the importance of segmenting donors based on their identification with the moral values of an organization. This implies that communication strategies for each target group should be tailored to effectively communicate the values and activities of an organization to each specific group. A one-size-fits-all approach may not be as effective as targeted communication strategies for each group.

Finally, this study emphasizes the importance of NGO accountability in building strong donor relationships by demonstrating NGO *quality*. Fundraising campaigns should consider the importance of communicating performance and achievements for building strong relationships with donors. This may involve providing regular updates on an organization's activities, highlighting the impact of donations, and recognizing donors' contributions to the organization's goals. Overall, these implications underscore the importance of building and maintaining strong relationships with donors to establish and maintain strong NGO brand equity.

## 5 | LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

We acknowledge some limitations of our study, which merit further research. First, although there are important conceptual differences among NPOs and NGOs, in some cases, it is difficult to differentiate between the two. More granular distinctions in these types of organizations will be interesting to explore. Second, as our study is exploratory in nature, our results do not provide direct insights into the effects and interrelations of the dimensions proposed for constructing a donor-based brand equity model. This is a topic that could be explored further in

future research. Despite these limitations, we believe that our review provides valuable insights and a solid foundation for future research in this field.

Our findings also suggest several research avenues that can help NGOs build stronger brands and increase their social impacts.

First, our results suggest that brand associations should be more related to an NGO's values, objectives and reputation than to specific personality traits, which are more relevant in other NPOs. Hence, we suggest that tangible associations such as personnel or physical facilities, brand logos, or media content might also be worth studying.

Second, research should further investigate how donors perceive NGO quality, an important dimension that is absent in the NPO literature. We propose the use of accountability tools to demonstrate organizational reliability and legitimacy to assess perceived NGO quality. Some works have studied the effects that voluntary NPO public disclosure have on donors (Saxton et al., 2014); however, these results have not been incorporated as elements to assess perceived NGO quality using brand equity.

Third, regarding brand loyalty, it is important to investigate NGO brand loyalty when donors may support multiple various NGOs simultaneously. In addition to behavioral commitment through donation, we propose examining donors' attitudinal commitment, as their emotional connection with a cause may enhance their loyalty to an NGO. Therefore, we suggest extending the concept of commitment by considering both behavioral and attitudinal dimensions.

Fourth, moral self-identification with NGO causes should be explored to understand how to trigger donor intention. Certain elements, such as NGO cause, size, and whether an NGO is local or international, should be investigated; these may impact donor self-donor identification with an NGO brand.

Finally, few studies have explored how marketing mix influences brand equity formation. We thus suggest that future research examines how to build stronger NGO brands, exploring the impact of the marketing mix, including social media and cause-related marketing.

## CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

## DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no new data were created or analyzed in this study.

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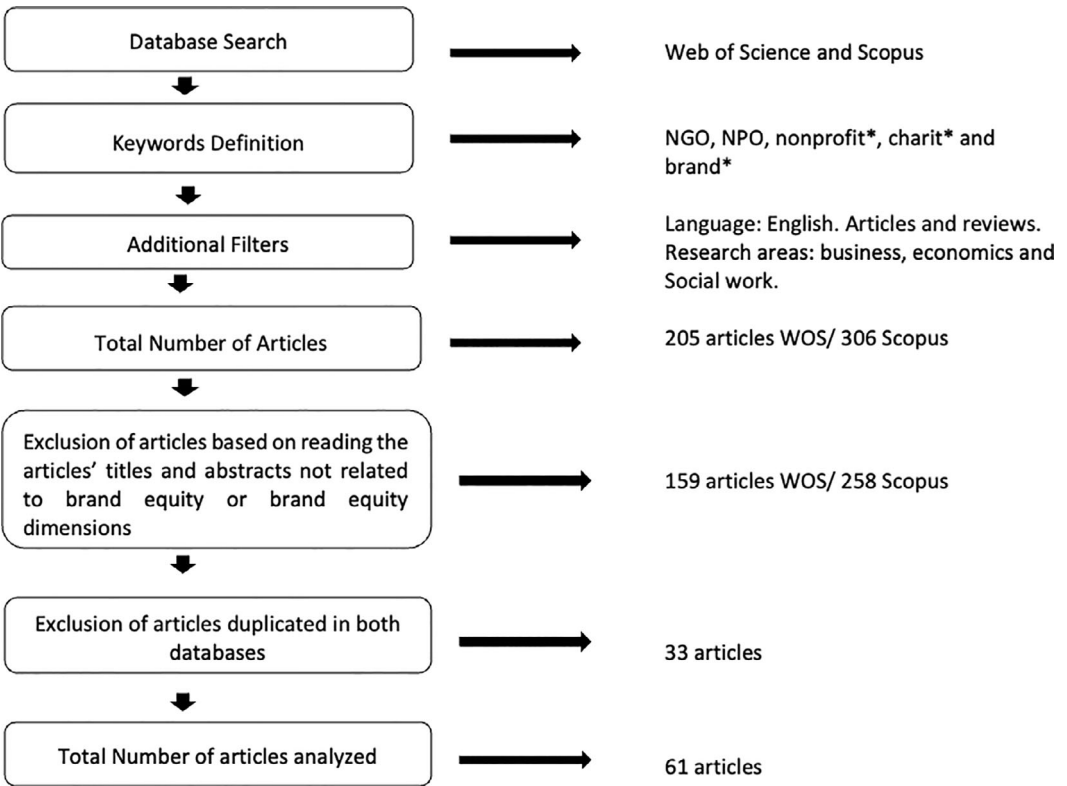
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## APPENDIX 1: METHOD

To analyze the NGO and NPO brand equity literature, the WOS Core Collection and Scopus databases were used as the main sources for the research. The string defined for the literature search was “*NPO OR nonprofit OR charity\* OR NGO OR nonforprofit OR nonprofit AND Brand\**” to collect any brand article related to any of the nomenclatures used for NPOs and NGOs in the literature. We limited the search to articles and reviews in English for the research areas of business, economic, and social work. This search provided 205 articles in WOS and 306 in SCOPUS.

We then examined all article titles and abstracts to excluded duplicates and those that did not address NGO or NPO brand equity or brand equity dimensions. After analysis and exclusion, our sample for the systematic review included 61 articles. The article selection and exclusion processes are detailed in the figure below:



APPENDIX 2: BRAND EQUITY DIMENSIONS IN NPO LITERATURE

TABLE A1 Brand awareness in NPO literature.

| Author                    | Dimensions measured                 | NPO researched                                                      | Scale used                                     | Effects                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Faircloth (2005)          | Recall and familiarity              | NPO for people with developmental disabilities (USA)                | Oliver and Bearden (1985); Bloch et al. (1989) | Recall: nonsignificant effect.<br>Familiarity: negative effect                            |
| Hou et al. (2009)         | Recall and familiarity              | 393 donors and potential donors (China)                             | Faircloth (2005)                               | Recall: positive effect.<br>Familiarity: positive effect                                  |
| Juntunen et al. (2013)    | Recall and recognition              | Military driving school (Finnish Defense Forces)                    | Davis et al. (2008)                            | Recall: positive effect.<br>Recognition: positive effect                                  |
| Paço et al. (2014)        | Familiarity                         | Doctors of the World, Red Cross, Cáritas, UNICEF and AMI (Portugal) | Faircloth (2005)                               | Familiarity: negative effect                                                              |
| Boenigk and Becker (2016) | Recall and recognition              | 40 NPOs (Germany)                                                   | Keller (1993); Aaker (1996)                    | Recall: positive effect.<br>Recognition: positive effect                                  |
| Kashif et al. (2018)      | Recall, recognition and familiarity | 448 active Muslim donors (Pakistan)                                 | Tong and Hawly (2009)                          | Recall: positive effect.<br>Recognition: positive effect.<br>Familiarity: positive effect |
| Dogan et al. (2021)       | Familiarity                         | Doctors Worldwide (Turkey)                                          | Oliver and Bearden (1985)                      | Familiarity: positive effect                                                              |

TABLE A2 Brand associations in NPO literature.

| Author                     | Dimensions measured               | NPO researched                                                                                                 | Scale used/analyzed traits                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bennett and Gabriel (2000) | Brand image                       | Two leading UK Charities                                                                                       | Own research. <i>Emotive altruism; Efficiency; Trust; Modernity</i>                                                                                             |
| Bennett and Gabriel (2003) | Brand image                       | UK major Charities                                                                                             | Own research. <i>Dynamism; Idealism; Compassion, Political orientation; Reputation; Focus on beneficiaries</i>                                                  |
| Faircloth (2005)           | Brand image and brand personality | NPO for people with developmental disabilities (USA)                                                           | Brand image: Malhotra (1981); Osgood et al. (1957). <i>Character; Scale</i> . Brand personality: Fournier (1998); Aaker (1996). <i>Respect; Differentiation</i> |
| Venable et al. (2005)      | Brand personality                 | Health and environment, rights, arts, and humanities (six of each group) (USA)                                 | Aaker (1997) <i>Integrity; Ruggedness; Sophistication</i>                                                                                                       |
| Sargeant et al. (2008)     | Brand personality                 | Nine large charities (UK)                                                                                      | Own research. Sector: <i>Benevolence; progression</i> . Organization: <i>Emotional engagement; performance</i> . Cause: <i>Class; Faith; Service</i>            |
| Voeth and Herbst (2008)    | Brand personality                 | German Red Cross, AOK, Greenpeace, BUND, WWF, Deutsche Welthungerhilfe, Amnistia International, SOS-Child Care | Own scale based on Aaker (1997). <i>Social Competence and Trust. Emotion and assertiveness. Sophistication</i>                                                  |
| Hou et al. (2009)          | Brand image and brand personality | 393 donors and potential donors (China)                                                                        | Faircloth (2005). Brand image: <i>Character and scale</i> . Brand personality: <i>Respect and differentiation</i>                                               |
| Michel and Rieunier (2012) | Brand image                       | Red Cross, AFM-Telethon, UNICEF, Handicap International, Doctors without borders (France)                      | Bennet and Gabriel (2003). <i>Usefulness; efficiency; affect; dynamism</i>                                                                                      |
| Juntunen et al. (2013)     | Brand image                       | Military driving school (Finnish Defense Forces)                                                               | Davis et al. (2008). <i>Reliability; respect</i>                                                                                                                |
| Michaelidou et al. (2015)  | Brand image                       | Barnardo's and BBC Children (UK)                                                                               | Michel and Rieunier (2012). <i>Usefulness; efficiency; affect; dynamism; reliability; ethically</i>                                                             |
| Shehu et al. (2016)        | Brand personality                 | Blood donation (Germany).                                                                                      | Venable et al. (2005). <i>Integrity; nurturance; ruggedness; sophistication</i>                                                                                 |
| Kashif et al. (2018)       | Brand associations                | 448 active Muslim donors (Pakistan)                                                                            | Tong & Hawly (2009). <i>Respect; admiration; trust</i>                                                                                                          |

TABLE A3 Brand loyalty in NPO literature.

| Authors                    | Dimensions measured            | NPO researched                      | Scale used                                              |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Sargeant and Lee (2004)    | Relationship commitment        | 4 NPOs (UK)                         | Own development                                         |
| Boenigk and Helming (2013) | NPO identification and loyalty | 2 NPOs (Germany)                    | Mael and Ashforth (1992); Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007) |
| Boenigk and Becker (2016)  | Brand commitment and loyalty   | 40 NPOs (Germany)                   | Sargeant and Lee (2004)                                 |
| Kashif et al. (2018)       | Loyalty                        | 448 active Muslim donors (Pakistan) | Tong and Hawly (2009)                                   |

TABLE A4 Perceived quality in NPO literature.

| Authors                             | Dimensions measured              | NPO researched                                       | Scale used                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Laidler-Kylander and Simonin (2009) | Trustworthy                      | Care; Oxfam, World Vision                            | Own research                                                                                          |
| Jones and Shandiz (2015)            | Perceived quality using SERVQUAL | NPO that assisted families with financial debt (USA) | Parasuraman et al. (1991). <i>Reliability; assurance; empathy; tangibles</i>                          |
| Boenigk and Becker (2016)           | Brand trust                      | 40 NPOs (Germany)                                    | Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007). <i>Ethically; reliability.</i>                                         |
| Kashif et al. (2018)                | Perceived quality                | 448 active Muslim donors (Pakistan)                  | Tong and Hawly (2009)                                                                                 |
| Katz (2018)                         | Trust                            | Donors and potential donors (Israel)                 | Own questionnaire. <i>Confidence; integrity; trust; influence; competence; efficiency; usefulness</i> |